global nuclear disarmament in the same way he believed in equal civil rights for African Americans. The exigencies of politics and the constraints of compromise, however, precluded radical action. Although the tangible consequences of the crisis for arms control were positive contributions to better international relations, underlying dynamics of ideology, technology and politics remained. And despite his attraction to having a small number of nuclear weapons to provide a credible deterrent, he succumbed to the arguments of Maxwell Taylor and Robert McNamara to build a huge arsenal of Minuteman ICBMs and Polaris SLBMs. In December 1962 McNamara advised, 'I would say take [my] recommendation and double it and buy it.'[38] The eventual outcome was over a thousand Minuteman and nearly seven hundred Polaris missiles.

Business as usual?

On 22 October 1962 Charles de Gaulle asked Dean Acheson whether he was there to consult or inform him of how Kennedy wished to proceed against the missiles in Cuban. De Gaulle had long concluded that France needed nuclear weapons of its own. It was the same conclusion that the British had reached in the time of Clement Attlee. Paris continued with the development of its *force de frappe* and de Gaulle pursued a political agenda that, in 1966, led to France's withdrawal from NATO's integrated military command structure and the withdrawal of NATO bases from French territory.

The most immediate nuclear decision confronting Harold Macmillan was how to deal with Washington's cancellation of the US Skybolt air-launched ballistic missile. Skybolt was intended to provide Bomber Command with the ability to sustain what London considered a credible national deterrent. Kennedy's subsequent decision to provide Polaris (and to offer it to the French) demonstrated that the missile crisis had not elevated non-proliferation over intra-alliance politics. The missile crisis undoubtedly strengthened the personal relationship between Macmillan and Kennedy. Did the missile crisis change the political dynamics? McGeorge Bundy's assessment was that: